

Incompatible ALLIES

The TDP chief is known for forging alliances but this time the mutual distrust among the partners threatens his prospects

Photographs by A. PRABHAKAR RAO



| By Amarnath K. Menon |

Before 2004, when he was unseated from the chief minister's chair, Chandrababu Naidu unveiled Vision 2020, his dream of a golden era for Andhra Pradesh. That dream took a beating, along with his image as a poster boy for economic reforms and hi-tech revolution, but now, just before Election 2009, here comes another vision statement, not quite 20-20 but tempered by hindsight. It's called Mahakutami, or Grand Alliance, an unlikely electoral sandwich he has put together. This time, he's playing it a lot safer by tying up with other parties to broaden his electoral clout.

It's quite a remarkable achievement considering that Naidu has won over parties which were Congress allies in 2004. Moreover, none of them are natural allies. One is K. Chandrasekhara Rao and his Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) which envisages a separate state as its only plank. Rao and Naidu were sworn enemies. The others in the alliance are the CPI and the CPI(M), also ideological opposites but not such odd bedfellows considering Naidu's remarkable makeover.

The man who assiduously projected himself as an ultra moderniser and created a hi-tech hub called Cyberabad, is now projecting an image that is the virtual opposite of his earlier avatar. Last year, he travelled for 117 days across the state on his

NAIDU (RIGHT) WITH RAO (SECOND FROM LEFT) AND LEFT LEADERS AT THE GRAND ALLIANCE LAUNCH